

Case study: UPI/Online payment fraud

This case study is about UPI/online payment fraud, which has become very common in recent times due to the increase in digital transactions. In this type of fraud, scammers contact people by pretending to be bank officials, customer support agents, or even employees from trusted organizations. They usually create a sense of urgency or fear by saying that the user's bank account will be blocked or that there is an issue with a recent transaction. In some cases, they also send fake links or ask the user to install unknown applications. Once the victim shares sensitive information like OTP, PIN, or clicks on a malicious link, the scammer gains access to their account and transfers money without permission.

For example, consider a fictional case of a college student named Riya. She received a phone call from a person claiming to be from her bank. The caller spoke confidently and informed her that her account would be blocked due to incomplete verification. He asked her to quickly confirm her details and share the OTP sent to her phone. Since the situation sounded urgent and real, Riya trusted the caller and shared the OTP without thinking much. Within a few minutes, ₹15,000 was deducted from her bank account. She later realized that she had been scammed, but by that time, the money had already been transferred and could not be easily recovered.

Such cases are increasing because many people are not fully aware of online safety practices. Scammers take advantage of fear, panic, and lack of awareness rather than using complex

technical methods. This case highlights the importance of staying alert while using digital payment systems.

Prevention

To stay safe from cybercrime, especially UPI fraud, it is important to follow simple but effective precautions.

- never share your OTP, PIN, or banking passwords with anyone, even if they claim to be from a bank.
- always verify unknown calls or messages before taking any action.
- avoid clicking on suspicious links or downloading unknown apps.
- enable two-factor authentication for added security.
- use official banking apps only and keep them updated regularly.
- check transaction details carefully before confirming any payment.
- report any suspicious activity immediately to the **National Cyber Crime Portal (cybercrime.gov.in)** or call the **Helpline 1930**.
- always stay aware and educated about common online scams.